higher concerns about mortality en route but also lower return migration rates. Sailing trips around the Cape of Good Hope would initially take up to three months but this reduced to one or two months after the Suez Canal opened in 1869. Ship rations included dal, ghee, mustard oil, vegetables, fish or flesh, salt, ‘curry stuff’ and rice for the rice-eaters and flour for the flour-eaters, reflecting India’s north–south dietary divide.[7] Ships were most often named after famous people. During 1856–57, the ships that left Calcutta for the West Indies were the *Wellesley*, *Bucephalus*, *Robert Seppings*, *Adelaide*, *Roman Emperor*, *George Seymour*, *Maidstone*, *Eveline*, *Merchantman*, *Granville*, *Burmah* and the *Scindian*. They were not always named after European rulers—one ship was called Shah Jehan, but as luck would have it, it caught fire in June 1859 and all 300 people on board died.

The abolition of slavery in British colonies across the Atlantic led to the first batch of indentured Indian labour arriving in British Guiana in 1838. The terrain of Guyana was not particularly conducive to sugar plantations, but the Dutch had reclaimed and irrigated the land to make the coastland habitable in the 17th century, replete with dykes and dams.[8] The African slave labourers who worked on the sugar plantations resisted the governing elite after their emancipation from British rule in the 1830s, leading to the search for alternate labour, and the eventual entry of Indians, or East Indians as they were called, to differentiate them from the Native American Indians. Since Africans subsidized the introduction of Indian indenture labour through tax payments, their resentment also grew against the Indians.

Between 1838 and 1917, over 2,00,000 Indian labourers migrated to British Guiana, and less than a third returned to India. Almost all the migrants traced their roots to the Bhojpuri-speaking tracts of the Gangetic plains, a core area of the Great Indian Migration Wave. A sixth of the migrants were Muslim, another sixth were upper castes, a third were low-caste or outcaste and another third were middling artisan and agricultural castes. They were mostly men, but were over time accompanied by their wives and even single women. In her memoir, *Coolie Woman*, Gaiutra Bahadur traced the journey of her great-grandmother, a Brahmin woman